

Human Rights

How has the protection of human rights changed over time? How does it differ across countries, and between social groups? Explore global data on human rights.

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Introduction

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Research & Writing

Charts

Human rights are rights that all people have, regardless of their country, gender, sexuality, ethnicity, or any other trait.

Among others, this includes: physical integrity rights, such as not being killed or tortured; civil rights, such as practicing their religion and moving freely in their country; and political rights, such as freedoms of speech and association.

The protection of these rights allows people to live the lives they want and to thrive in them.

Human rights have become much more protected, but this varies a lot between countries. And not everyone enjoys the same protections: people are often marginalized because of their gender, sexuality, or ethnicity.

On this page, you can find data, visualizations, and writing on how the protection of human rights has changed over time, how it differs across countries, and how it varies between people of different genders, sexualities, and ethnicities.

We have additional topic pages related to people's economic and social rights, such as on [food](#), [health](#), and [education](#), and dedicated topic pages for [women's rights](#) and [LGBT+ rights](#).

Key Insights on Human Rights

Human rights have become much more protected around the world

Human rights are much more protected in some countries than in others

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Human rights have become much more protected around the world

Human rights are much better protected than they were one or two hundred years ago.

In the late 18th century, human rights were poorly protected. In many countries, people's [physical integrity](#)  and [private](#)  and [political](#)  civil liberties were not respected by their governments. The chart shows — based on data from Varieties of Democracy — that countries received an average score of only 0.3, on a scale from 0 to 1 (most rights).

Importantly, this early data does not include many countries that were colonies before 1900. There, human rights were likely protected even less.

During the 19th century, the protection of human rights slowly improved. But in the first half of the 20th century, some of this progress was undone, particularly during the World Wars.

The protection of human rights then improved massively in the second half of the 20th century. However, this progress has not been linear: there have been setbacks in the 1970s and recent years.

Despite these setbacks, human rights remain much more protected than only half a century ago.